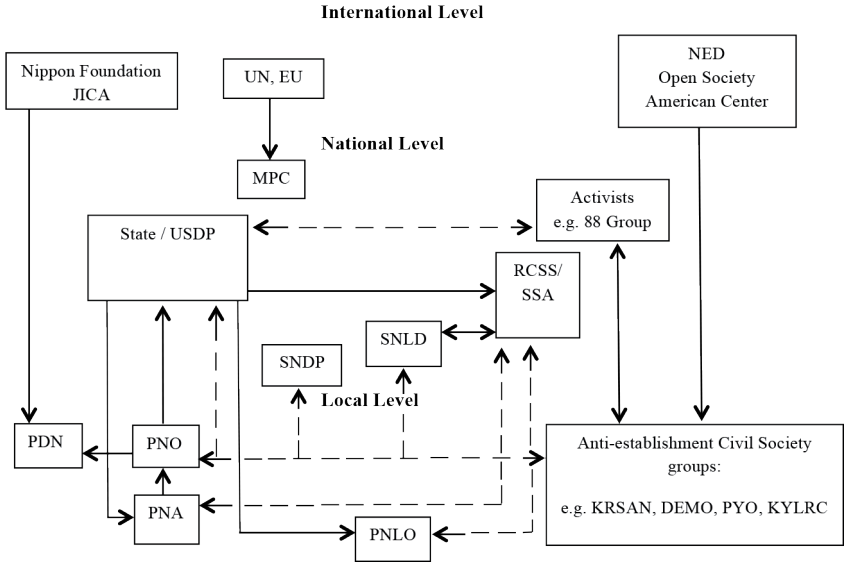
Figure 5.4. The political landscape in the southern Shan State



ASSESSING THE EFFECTIVENESS OF CO-OPTATION ON THE FRONTIER

In the frontier pacification project, the state has used co-optation at the macro level to secure loyalty and control. At the micro level however, while patronage matters, finding the right broker to deliver political objectives is equally important, as Aspinall and As'ad show in their study of elections in Indonesia. They conclude "what gave the victor his winning edge were state-centred forms of patronage and assiduous networking with a group we have described … as state brokers" (Aspinall and As'ad 2015, p. 191). Following their logic, the success of the government frontier policy in southern Shan State depends on the effectiveness of the brokers employed.

As a well-rewarded broker, Nay Win Tun needs to deliver on the political objective of securing control in the area. This can be determined by examining the PNO's performance in the 2010 and 2015 elections. In the 2010 election, the PNO won all the seats available for Pa-O Special Region 6. This result should not come as a surprise, as voting irregularities marred the election, and the PNO had no competitor locally at that time. However, the PNO managed to retain all its seats in the 2015 election; it was